



WELSH MINING

Wales was until recently a major supplier of coal, and many towns and villages depended on the mines for their existence. But the coal industry has now been dismantled and large amounts of coal are imported, so that mines all over the UK have closed down. Wales especially was badly affected, leading to high unemployment in former mining areas. Some towns, however, have succeeded in attracting new industries and the beautiful mountainous scenery brings increasing numbers of tourists.



SPORTS

Sports are close to the hearts of many British people. Soccer and rugby are generally played in the winter, and cricket and golf are popular in the summer months. Rugby, cricket, and golf – now played all over the world – originated in the UK, and the rules of soccer developed from games played in English boys' schools.

Hat made from
Welsh wool



Scottish tartan
scarf

Vest made from
Irish linen



NATIONAL IDENTITY

The UK's government is based at Westminster in London, England, but a separate Scottish Parliament and Welsh Assembly – both with certain “devolved” powers – were approved by referendum and were first elected in May 1999. Strong national identities are also deeply rooted through cultural and historic ties as well as by traditional arts, crafts and customs.



Banking and
financial
services in
particular
have helped
boost the
UK economy.

INDUSTRY

Heavy industry once supplied many jobs in the UK, but this pattern has changed. Now light engineering products, machinery, cars, and weapons are the major exports, and large numbers of people are employed in financial and service industries. These have helped an economy that was flagging, partly because the UK has to import so much of its food and raw materials. Many powerful multinational companies, with offices throughout the world, are also based here.



NORTHERN IRELAND

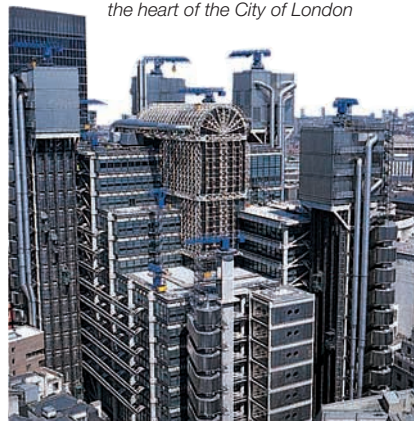
Since the 1960s Northern Ireland and its capital, Belfast (above), have suffered violent conflict. The large Protestant community, descended from British settlers, wants to stay within the UK, while Irish Catholics, who have been discriminated against in jobs and housing, wish to join southern Ireland. Both sides have kept up terrorist campaigns, and the Catholic Irish Republican Army has also bombed the British mainland. A peace agreement was signed on Good Friday in April 1998, but getting the two communities to share political power has proved difficult.

Find out more

COAL MINING: 96, 114, 162
ETHNIC MIX: 81
EUROPEAN CITIES: 80
SERVICE INDUSTRIES: 281

FINANCE

Each day more currency changes hands in London than in any other city in the world. The City of London, or the “square mile” as it is also known, contains more than 500 banks, attracted to the capital because of its leading role in world finance. This situation partly stems from the former importance of the British Empire, but today it has more to do with the city's location – midway between Tokyo and New York, the other main world financial centers – and the expertise in banking and financial services built up over many years.



The Lloyd's Insurance Building in
the heart of the City of London